FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Even if he is new to leadership, Tarique Rahman's arrival at the helm of Bangladesh is a comforting restoration of normalcy. What we could have had instead is a descent into anarchy, a plunge into radicalism or an unholy cocktail of both. Compared to that, the non-virtues here are decidedly milder. In a familiar South Asian pattern, we have a legatee of one part of Bangladesh's political binary: Tarique, 60, is the son of former prime minister Begum Khaleda Zia and former president Ziaur Rahman, founder of the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP). So, he inherits the political DNA of a formation that has historically been less friendly to India, as well as more accommodating of Islamism, compared to its arch-rival, the Awami League led by Sheikh Hasina. A natural tilt towards Pakistan was implicit in this. But this misses a duality at the heart of the BNP. In 2026, the resounding mandate Tarique got is also one that represents Bangladesh's refusal to hand over its destiny to rampaging religious fundamentalism.



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For India, that is a good start. The eastern neighbourhood reclaims its equilibrium in some measure. Hasina's overtly pro-India stance, sustained since 2009, had become the cornerstone of New Delhi's South Asia strategy. The Awami years saw the dismantling of cross-border bases of Northeast insurgent groups, contributing to stability in that region. But within Bangladesh, that very proximity turned into a liability as Hasina became increasingly authoritarian. Anti-Hasina sentiment was often refracted as anti-India rhetoric. That was hardly the desired dividend of diplomacy. So, if Tarique seeks to assert a 'Bangladesh First' stance, mature pragmatism dictates that New Delhi see it not as hostility but as a political necessity it can live with. This is the logic behind Prime Minister Narendra Modi's swift move to congratulate Tarique. He was the first global leader to do so.

The alternative scenarios were far more troubling. In his belated turn as head of state, economist Muhammad Yunus did far more than stall infrastructure projects: his two-year interim government openly fanned anti-India sentiment, Yunus himself not shying from striking a controversial tone with throwaway remarks, say, on the "landlocked" Northeast. India was staring at the spectre of a power vacuum or an inimical regime led by Islamists. That would have meant India's eastern neighbourhood turning into a staging post for Pakistan or, worse, for China. Big-power rivalry just across India's borders would have created new uncertainties. A stable, legitimate and mainstream government averts that possibility.

New Delhi must now move with tact to resolve all outstanding issues. India's first concern is security. Being assuaged on that front is predicated on Tarique shedding the more unsavoury bits from BNP's past. At a bare minimum, India needs assurances that Bangladeshi territory won't be used for activities hostile to Indian interests, whether relating to the Northeast or to radical networks. The concerns sharpen with the electoral resurgence of Jamaat-e-Islami in districts bordering West Bengal. Tarique's father, an independence war hero who emerged at the helm of a junta in 1975, is credited with initiating the pro-Islamisation strain in Bangladesh's politics. His mother, Khaleda Zia, continued it by entering into a tactical understanding with the Jamaat 25 years ago. But then, Ziaur Rahman also inaugurated multi-party democracy and economic reforms in Bangladesh. This BNP blueprint is often credited with putting it on the path where it rose out of grinding poverty: now Bangladesh is on a par with India on human development indices and is about to graduate out of 'Least Developed Country' status in 2026. Khaleda also brought far-reaching reforms, including free girls' education. That's what has borne fruit with Tarique's mandate, which flowed in part from a massive 'she vote'. It is a happy irony that the BNP became the natural harbour for the anti-Jamaat vote.

Geopolitics will test this equilibrium. In January, the Yunus regime took China's ambassador to a strategic project site on the Teesta River, bordering Siliguri. A provocative gesture not lost on Delhi. From Tarique, India hopes for a change of tonality. Yet Teesta water-sharing remains a complex issue, not least due to the forbidding presence of Mamata Banerjee who blocked the 2011 deal with Hasina. Besides, India giving safe harbour to Hasina is bound to be a thorny issue. Migration remains a persistent migraine. But the larger problems Tarique faces are familiar to India: an economy deeply dependent on the garments industry and agriculture, which are unable to absorb the 2 million youth joining the workforce each year, let alone sustain its dreams. Youth unemployment, where Bangladesh matches India's 15.6 per cent, is a big worry since about a third of its 175 million population is in the 0-24 age group. With high outmigration, remittance flows create aspirational imbalances among those left behind. This underlying ferment is what led to the political tumult that unseated Hasina. The revolution had economic roots. That riddle is the unenviable legacy that Tarique inherits. For the moment, though, there is hope in the air. "There is visible relief that a centrist force like the BNP has come to power," says Assistant Editor Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, who was in Dhaka this week to bring us an exhaustive ground report.

For India, the task is to engage without illusion. A cooperative approach to trade, connectivity, water-sharing and security can anchor stability on the eastern frontier. Bangladesh is hopefully renewing its own tryst with destiny. It would be wise for India to offer a steadying hand.

(Aroon Purie)